B1 Speaking

Introductions and small talk

Start a conversation, keep it going with follow-up questions, and end it politely.

Small talk is short, friendly conversation with people you do not know well: at work, at a party, or waiting for a meeting. The secret is simple: answer, add one detail, then ask a question back.

Stage	Useful phrases
Starting	*Hi, I'm Hamad. I don't think we've met. Nice to meet you.*
Safe topics	*How do you know Sara? Have you been here before? Busy week?*
Answer + detail + question	*I work in IT, mostly with websites. What about you?*
Showing interest	*Really? That sounds interesting. How long have you done that?*
Ending politely	*It was nice talking to you. I'd better get a coffee before it starts.*

The three-step answer. A one-word reply ends the conversation. *Yes* becomes *Yes, I came last year too. It was much smaller then. Is it your first time?*

Common mistake. Asking very personal questions too soon, such as salary, age or marriage. Keep to work, travel, the event, the weather and hobbies until you know the person better.

Practice

1. Introduce yourself to someone you have not met at a conference.
2. Someone asks "Do you live near here?" Give a three-step answer.

3. Show interest: Someone says "I've just come back from Japan."
4. Which question is not suitable for small talk? (a) How was your journey? (b) How much do you earn? (c) Have you tried the food here?
5. End the conversation politely because your meeting is starting.

▼ **Show answers**

1. Hi, I'm [name]. I don't think we've met. Nice to meet you.
2. For example: Not far, about ten minutes by car. It's quite a quiet area. What about you?
3. Really? How was it? / That sounds amazing. What did you enjoy most?
4. (b)
5. It was really nice talking to you. I'd better go, my meeting is about to start.